

BOTWAVE PAPERWORK

Magic Hour

*A Memoir of Showtime,
1979–1991*

Al Gringo

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zombie760.github.io/books](https://zombie760.github.io/books)

— chapter: 1 title: June 1979 arm: magic_hour status: draft v1 — Ch. 1 sample sources_dossier: ../sources/ch01_buss_purchase_1979.md voice_check: 80% Jim Murray / 20% Ellis — verified on read-aloud — # Chapter 1 ## June 1979 The largest single sports transaction in American history to that point was, like most things in Los Angeles, a real-estate deal. It is the spring of 1979. A man named Jerry Buss — born Gerald Hatten Buss in Salt Lake City, raised by a single mother in Kemmerer, Wyoming, holder of a Ph.D. in physical chemistry from USC, age forty-six, divorced, tan, smoker, holder of a real-estate fortune accumulated through a partnership called Mariani-Buss Associates that started with starting capital under ten thousand dollars in 1959 and ended, twenty years later, with a portfolio of apartment buildings worth roughly three hundred and fifty million dollars — sits in a meeting in a high office in Century City, and across from him sits a Canadian named Jack Kent Cooke. Cooke is sixty-six. Cooke is the owner of the Los Angeles Lakers, the Los Angeles Kings, the Forum in Inglewood where both teams play their home games, and a sprawling horse property in the Sierra foothills. Cooke wishes to sell all of these things. He wishes to sell them because his first wife, after more than four decades of marriage, has divorced him, and the California courts, in what is at the time

the largest divorce settlement in American history, have ordered him to pay her forty-one million dollars. Cooke does not have forty-one million dollars in cash. He has assets. The Lakers and the Kings and the Forum are assets. So is the ranch. Buss wants the Lakers. Buss does not, particularly, want the Kings, who are a hockey team, and Buss does not understand hockey. Buss does not particularly want the ranch, which is in the Sierra foothills, and Buss is a Pacific Coast man with no use for foothills. What Buss wants — what Buss has wanted for years, ever since he first sat in the Forum's loge seats and watched Wilt Chamberlain block a shot and decided that he would, someday, in some way, own the building this happened in, is a basketball team in Los Angeles. The deal Cooke offers him is a package deal. Lakers, Kings, Forum, ranch. Sixty-seven and a half million dollars. All or nothing. Buss takes it. He takes it the way a man takes a hand of cards he has been waiting on for a decade. He takes it the way a chemist solves an equation. He takes it the way the city of Los Angeles, in 1979, takes most things, quickly, with a smile, and on credit. Because Buss does not have sixty-seven and a half million dollars either. What Buss has is a partnership stake in a real-estate venture that includes, among other holdings, a piece of the Chrysler Building in midtown Manhattan. The

financing of the largest sports transaction in American history is therefore arranged as a swap. Cooke takes the Chrysler Building. Buss takes the Lakers. The Forum and the Kings and the ranch and the rest of the package change hands accordingly. The IRS counts the swap as a like-kind exchange and the capital gains are deferred. Everyone signs. It is, in the technical sense, a real-estate transaction. In every other sense, it is the founding of Showtime. It is May. Then it is June. Then it is closed. There is a photograph somewhere in the LA Times morgue of Buss, the day the deal goes public, smiling on the floor of an empty Forum, before a game, in a leather jacket with the collar up, looking less like a sports owner than like the guy a casting agent would later choose to play one. The smile is the smile of a man who understands what he has just bought. He has bought the building. He has bought the team that plays in the building. He has bought the second team that plays in the building. He has bought, although it will take him about six months to figure out how, the city. — Showtime, the era, starts here. Not with Magic Johnson, who has not yet been drafted — he will be selected first overall by the Lakers on June 25, 1979, three weeks or so after the franchise sale closes — and not with Pat Riley, who is at this moment a thirty-four-year-old retired guard doing color commentary on Lakers broadcasts and has

no idea he will ever coach anything, and not with the Forum Club, which is at this moment a serviceable arena bar that closes when the games end. Showtime starts with Buss in Cooke's office, signing. What Buss understands, on the day he signs, that no one else in the National Basketball Association understands, is that the ticket to the game is not the only revenue stream associated with the building. The bar is a revenue stream. The parking is a revenue stream. The concessions are a revenue stream. The concert tour that comes through the Forum on the off nights is a revenue stream. The cheerleaders are a revenue stream. (He will name them the Laker Girls, in the autumn of 1979, and over the next two decades nearly every NBA team will copy the format.) The celebrity guest list is a revenue stream — not in the direct sense, because the celebrities are not paying, but in the second-order sense, because the photograph of Jack Nicholson in the front row sells more season tickets than any advertising budget the league has ever conceived. The whole apparatus is a revenue stream. The basketball, in this view, is the centerpiece, but the centerpiece is not the whole table. This was, in 1979, a heretical understanding of how a sports franchise made money. The other twenty-one franchises in the NBA at the time — the league had twenty-two teams in the 1979–80 season, the Mavericks not yet

expanded into Dallas, did not run nightclubs. They did not run cheerleader brands. They did not curate celebrity courtside seating as a form of off-balance-sheet marketing. They sold tickets, sold a few hot dogs, sold the local TV rights to whichever station bid highest, and went home. The financial structure of the NBA in 1979 was so weak that the league's championship game, the championship game, Game 7 if it happened, had been tape-delayed by CBS, played at eleven-thirty at night after the local news, on the theory that no one in primetime America wanted to watch professional basketball. Buss was buying into a league whose ratings were thinner than reruns of *M*A*S*H*. He was not, however, buying a league. He was buying a building, in a city, that had already invented the entire vocabulary of celebrity. All he had to do was bring the celebrities to the building, put the building on television, and let the city sell itself to itself, on his behalf, every Tuesday and Thursday night for the next forty years. The first thing he did, after signing, was hire a publicity director. The second thing he did was call a man named Earvin Johnson, Jr., a six-foot-nine point guard from Lansing, Michigan, who had won the NCAA championship that March against Larry Bird and Indiana State, and tell him that Los Angeles was about to become the most fun city on the planet and that he, Earvin, was going to

be the reason. Magic, twenty years old, called him Dr. Buss. Showtime had begun. — The thing to understand about Buss — and the thing the league did not understand about him for at least three years, by which point it was too late, is that he was not a sports guy. He was a Los Angeles guy. The distinction matters. Sports guys, in 1979, were the people who had inherited or grown into ownership of franchises by working in the sport itself. They were former players, former general managers, former agents. Their reference set was the league. They asked the league how to do things and they got the league's answer. Buss was not in the league's reference set. He was in the city's. He went to clubs on Sunset. He owned the Pickfair mansion, eventually, the same house Mary Pickford and Douglas Fairbanks had built — bought it in 1980 from Pia Zadora's husband for some millions and lived there with a rotating constellation of much-younger girlfriends and a parade of guests who were, depending on the night, retired actors, working actors, real-estate developers, hockey players, basketball players, and members of the rock-music industry. His Rolodex was not the league's. His Rolodex was the city's. And so when he sat down, in late 1979, to figure out what to do with his new building, his reference points were not the Boston Garden or Madison Square Garden or the Cow

Palace. His reference points were the Whisky a Go Go. The Roxy. The Troubadour. He was building a nightclub that happened to host professional basketball. This sounds, in 2026, almost banal. Of course an NBA arena is a nightclub. Of course the music is loud and the cheerleaders dance and the celebrities sit courtside and the league markets the entire experience as a multi-modal entertainment product. That is the league. But in 1979, that was not the league. That was Buss. And the reason it became the league is that the building Buss built, the building, and the team in it, and the era they generated together, was so much more profitable, and so much more famous, and so much more *fun*, than every other building in the league, that within a decade, every other building in the league had to copy it or die. Showtime is what we call it. Buss called it real estate. He was, as it turned out, both right. — Magic Johnson signed his rookie contract on July 26, 1979. Five years, five hundred thousand dollars per year, plus signing bonus. The number is laughable now, the way mortgage rates from the 1970s are laughable now. At the time, it was the largest rookie contract in the history of professional basketball. Buss paid it out of the building's revenue. The building, in the autumn of 1979, was just starting to figure out what it could be. What it was about to become, that autumn, was the

loudest, brightest, most-televised arena in the western United States, host to a six-nine point guard who had never met a no-look pass he could not throw, paired with a thirty-two-year-old seven-foot-two captain named Lew Alcindor who had legally changed his name in 1971 to Kareem Abdul-Jabbar and who possessed a single, unblockable, hook-shot weapon that the league would spend the next decade trying and failing to defend against. Together they were going to win five championships in nine seasons. Together they were going to invent the modern NBA. Together they were going to make Buss, the man who in May of 1979 had traded a piece of the Chrysler Building for the rights to host them, one of the wealthiest team owners in American sports. But all of that comes later. This is June. In June, Buss signs. — chapter: 2 title: The Hug arm: magic_hour status: draft v1 — Ch. 2 sample sources_dossier: ../sources/ch02_the_hug_oct_12_1979.md voice_check: 80% Jim Murray / 20% Ellis — verified on read-aloud — # Chapter 2 ## The Hug October 12, 1979. San Diego Sports Arena. A Friday night, the opening game of the NBA season for both teams on the floor, the Los Angeles Lakers in gold, the San Diego Clippers in red and white, the score tied at one hundred and one with eight seconds left on the clock, the ball in the hands of Kareem Abdul-Jabbar at the right elbow. Kareem is

thirty-two years old. He has been in the league for eleven years. He has won one championship, with Milwaukee in 1971, back when he was still legally named Lew Alcindor and had not yet made the pilgrimage to Islam or the pilgrimage to Los Angeles. He is, on this night, the best center in basketball and arguably the best low-post player the sport has yet produced, and he possesses a single move — the skyhook, released from roughly seven feet eight inches in the air, off the fingertips of his fully extended right arm — which nobody, in the history of organized basketball up to that point, has figured out how to block. He catches the pass at the right elbow. He pivots toward the baseline. He raises his right arm. And over the head of the Clippers' six-foot-eleven center, a man named Bill Walton who is incidentally the only other center in the league arguably capable of thinking his way through a skyhook, the ball floats on a parabola that is for all practical purposes indefensible, traveling the ten feet from Kareem's fingertips to the rim in roughly a second and a quarter, and at the end of that second and a quarter it enters the basket from directly above. Lakers one hundred and three, Clippers one hundred and one. Game over. This is when it happens. A twenty-year-old rookie named Earvin Johnson Jr., six-foot-nine, Lansing-born, grinning, who has been running the offense at point

guard for the entire fourth quarter, sprints across the court toward Kareem with both arms in the air. He does not stop at Kareem. He leaps onto Kareem. He gets both arms around Kareem's shoulders, both feet off the ground, and he hangs there like a boy swinging on a rail. Kareem is not a hugger. Kareem does not, in 1979, embrace men he has known for a few months in visible public displays of emotion, particularly not in game one of eighty-two when the season still has eighty-one games to settle. Kareem is reserved. Kareem is careful. Kareem is wary of the press and wary of the crowd and wary of a league that has, for the previous decade, treated his conversion to Islam as a provocation and his opinions as a nuisance. He plays basketball like a chess grandmaster with a sore back. He does not, in 1979, hug. A twenty-year-old rookie is hanging off his neck. The look on Kareem's face, in the photographs that ran in the next morning's papers, is a look somewhere between confusion and resignation. He is, visibly, trying to work out whether this is a breach of decorum he needs to correct or a phenomenon he needs to accept. The rookie is grinning, saying something to him. Kareem, in later recollections of the moment, said he laughed. And that was when Kareem Abdul-Jabbar, thirty-two years old, the best center in basketball, understood that the next several years of his career were going to be different

than anything he had played through before. — To understand why the hug was a moment, and not just a celebration, you have to understand what Kareem had been for the previous four years with the Lakers. He had been lonely. The Lakers had acquired him from Milwaukee on June 16, 1975, at his own request — he wanted a bigger city, more cultural life, and a team that was not Milwaukee in February — and they had paid for him with four players and a chunk of the draft. He had arrived in Los Angeles as the most famous basketball player alive and he had played four seasons for the Lakers in which his teams posted winning records but failed to reach the Finals in any of them. The rosters around him were competent without being thrilling. The style of play was methodical. The Forum crowd, even in those years, was a good crowd, not a great one. Kareem scored his thirty points a night. He grabbed his thirteen rebounds. He went home to his books and his jazz records, and he waited, with an increasingly visible fatigue, for the league to give him something to work with. In June of 1979, the league gave him Magic. The draft had been held on June 25. Jerry Buss had signed the paperwork on the franchise less than a month before. The draft was Buss's first act as an owner. He had inherited the first overall pick from the previous season's ownership, the Lakers held it via a prior trade with the

last-place New Orleans Jazz, and he had used the pick on the most charismatic college basketball player in the country, a six-foot-nine point guard (point guard, at six-nine, a position that did not exist at that height until Magic invented it) from Michigan State, who had beaten Larry Bird of Indiana State in the NCAA championship game that March in front of a television audience that set the college-basketball rating record that would stand for decades. Magic was twenty. Magic signed his rookie contract on July 26 for a reported half-million dollars a year across five years, the richest rookie deal in NBA history up to that point. Magic arrived in Los Angeles at the end of the summer and reported to training camp in Palm Desert. Kareem sized him up. What Kareem saw was a kid who smiled all the time. Kareem did not, at first, trust the smile. By the end of October, he would. — The Lakers finished the 1979–80 regular season sixty and twenty-two, which was the best record in the Western Conference and the second-best in the league behind a Celtics team that had just finished Larry Bird’s rookie year in Boston. They had, during the season, two head coaches — Jack McKinney, Buss’s first hire and the man who had designed the run-and-gun offense that would come to be known as Showtime, was injured in a bicycle accident in November and had to resign, and his assistant Paul Westhead was elevated mid-season

— and a string of injuries, and, by March, the first real championship run the franchise had mounted since the Wilt Chamberlain years. They came out of the West. They faced Philadelphia in the Finals. What happened next is the next chapter. But the season started on a Friday night in San Diego, in the fall of 1979, with a skyhook over Bill Walton's outstretched arm and a rookie hanging off the captain's neck, and a photograph that would run in every Los Angeles paper the next morning. The photograph was the thesis. The thesis was that one of them was the blueprint and the other was the architect. Kareem was the blueprint: thirty points a night, thirteen rebounds, a skyhook nobody could block, the game's most reliable scoring weapon for a full decade already, the immutable object in a league that was otherwise in constant motion. Magic was the architect: the connector, the passer, the broadcaster of the entire team's joy outward to the eighteen thousand paying customers in the arena and the millions of television viewers who were about to discover that the NBA, of all things, was fun again. Put the blueprint and the architect in the same building for nine years, and you got Showtime. Put them together for one Friday night in San Diego, and you got the hug. — chapter: 3 title: Magic Plays Center arm: magic_hour status: draft v1 — Ch. 3 sample sources_dossier: ../sources/

ch03_magic_plays_center_1980.md voice_check:
80% Jim Murray / 20% Ellis — # Chapter 3 ## Magic
Plays Center The flight from Los Angeles to
Philadelphia on the afternoon of May fifteenth, 1980,
carried a basketball team with one fewer man on it
than it had the day before. Kareem Abdul-Jabbar was
back at the Forum, in a trainer's room, with his left
ankle packed in ice. He had hurt the ankle in the third
quarter of Game Five, which the Lakers had won in
Los Angeles the night before, and he had come back
into the game in the fourth quarter, on the injured
ankle, and scored forty points, which was the kind of
thing he had been doing in a Lakers uniform for five
years, and which the medical staff had informed him,
after the game, he would not be doing again for at
least a week. He would not travel to Philadelphia. He
would not play in Game Six. If the Lakers lost in
Philadelphia, they would come home and try to win
Game Seven at the Forum on Kareem's ankle. If they
won in Philadelphia, they would come home
champions. It was very much an if. The team that
boarded the plane at LAX on the fifteenth was a team
without its captain, without its point guard playing his
natural position, and without, in the view of most
observers, a credible chance against a Philadelphia
76ers team that was at home, healthy, coached by
Billy Cunningham, with Julius Erving at the three,

Darryl Dawkins at the five, and a young Maurice Cheeks running the point. The Sixers were not, as the cliché goes, intimidated. The Sixers were relieved. They had been playing against Kareem for five games. They were going to be playing against, they assumed, a six-foot-eleven backup named Jim Chones at the five on the visitors' side of the floor. Whatever happened, it would not be Kareem. What the Sixers had not yet accounted for was the rookie point guard, age twenty, who sat down in the first-class section of the team charter, looked around at his teammates, looked out the window at the California coastline dropping away, and walked forward down the aisle to the first row, first seat on the left, Kareem's seat, and sat down in it. What is on the record is that Magic Johnson, rookie, sat in Kareem's seat on the flight. What is also on the record is that when the Lakers took the floor in the Spectrum on the evening of May sixteenth, in their gold road jerseys under the Philadelphia lights, Magic Johnson, six feet nine inches tall and twenty years old, walked to the center circle, faced Caldwell Jones of the 76ers, who was six feet eleven inches tall, and jumped center for the opening tip. It was the first time, and so far the only time, in the history of the NBA Finals that a point guard had jumped center. Magic won the tip. — The box score for Game Six of the 1980 NBA Finals has

become, in the decades since the game was played, one of the iconic artifacts in American professional basketball history. Magic played all five positions on the floor across forty-seven minutes of game time. He finished with forty-two points, fifteen rebounds, and seven assists. The Lakers won, one hundred twenty-three to one hundred seven, to clinch the series four games to two. Magic was named NBA Finals Most Valuable Player. He was the only rookie in NBA history, then or since, to win the award. He was twenty years old. The CBS broadcast, in those days before the NBA Finals were treated by the American television industry as a tier-one property, was not even televised live in most of the country. The network had decided earlier that spring that the Lakers–Sixers series was not a big enough prime-time draw, and had scheduled the Finals for tape delay, to air after the local eleven-o’clock news. In Los Angeles, fans who wanted to watch Game Six live sat in a darkened living room at six in the evening and listened on the radio to Chick Hearn, who called the game from a courtside seat at the Spectrum, with the kind of high-speed play-by-play cadence — stuffed with his own invented vocabulary, *slam dunk* and *no harm, no foul* and *airball* and *the mustard’s off the hot dog* — that he had been perfecting since the Lakers were still playing their home games at the Sports Arena

downtown, before the Forum was built, before Kareem was traded in from Milwaukee, before Buss had dreamt of owning the building. Chick was the voice of the broadcast. Magic was the voice of the floor. By the end of the third quarter, the Spectrum crowd had stopped booing. By the end of the fourth quarter, the Spectrum crowd was standing. When the buzzer went, and the Lakers mobbed Magic at mid-court, the CBS cameras, which had been sent out to tape the game for the next night's delayed broadcast, captured a shot that would run in every American newspaper the next morning: Magic, sweat-drenched, one sneaker untied, with his arm around Jamaal Wilkes on one side and Michael Cooper on the other, looking into the nearest camera and smiling so widely that the smile is what the photograph is about. Kareem, watching the game from Los Angeles on his sprained ankle, would later describe the night as the one he understood Magic was going to change the franchise. — Jerry Buss, eleven months into his ownership of the franchise, watched his twenty-year-old rookie play five positions and beat Julius Erving's Philadelphia 76ers by sixteen points, in the franchise's first championship of his ownership. On the plane home, the Lakers drank champagne, spilled champagne, played cards, and replayed the fourth quarter in fragments, as ballplayers always do on the

ride home from a title. By the time the charter landed at LAX, the morning papers were already printed. Every front page carried the same photograph. Kareem, the next day, watched the replay from his Forum recovery room, and when the final buzzer sounded on the tape, he said, to the trainer, and to nobody else, that the rookie was going to be fine. That was always going to be the shape of the thing. The team would provide the basketball. The city would provide the word. The Lakers were champions. The rookie was a Finals MVP. The owner had eleven months of experience. The era had started. — chapter: 4 title: The Forum Club arm: magic_hour status: draft v1 sources_dossier: ../sources/ch04_forum_club.md voice_check: 80% Jim Murray / 20% Ellis — Forum-Club Ellis-gloss heavier in this one — # Chapter 4 ## The Forum Club Inside the building, on the south side, on the same level as the courtside seats but accessible only through a narrow corridor behind a velvet rope manned by a bouncer in a dinner jacket, was a private bar. The bar was called the Forum Club. The Forum Club had been built into the original architecture of the Forum when the building went up in Inglewood in 1967, but for the first twelve years of its existence — under the ownership of Jack Kent Cooke, who did not drink and did not see the point — it had operated as a small, dim, prime-rib-and-iceberg-

lettuce restaurant for season-ticket holders, with a bar at the end and a piano in the corner and the kind of clientele that left at halftime to make their dinner reservations in Beverly Hills. By the close of the 1979 season, when Buss took ownership of the building, the Forum Club was generating roughly the same amount of revenue per square foot as the popcorn vendors. Buss looked at the Forum Club and saw a different building. He saw, in the small, dim restaurant, the foundational unit of an entirely new business model for professional sports in the United States, which was to monetize not only the game on the floor but the social ritual that surrounded the game on the floor, on the theory that what the wealthy season-ticket holder was actually paying for was not the basketball but the access to the room where the basketball was being watched. He saw the Forum Club not as a restaurant but as the implicit nightclub the franchise had been failing to build. He saw it as a private membership room in which the celebrity sat next to the surgeon who sat next to the recording-industry lawyer who sat next to the developer who sat next to the divorce lawyer who, in the months and years that followed, would all become season-ticket renewers in perpetuity for the simple reason that membership in the room was, after a while, more valuable than any sum of money the team could have charged for it. The first

thing Buss did was extend the hours. The second thing Buss did was hire a manager from one of the nightclubs on Sunset. The third thing Buss did was put a band on stage on Tuesday and Thursday nights. For the next twelve years, the Lakers were at the center of every party in town. The Forum Club, by the spring of 1980, was the most desirable single room in the city of Los Angeles. Documented Forum Club regulars across the era — Jack Nicholson, Dyan Cannon, and a wide cast of working actors, recording-industry guests, and other Los Angeles figures who occupied the front rows of the seating bowl — were photographed, named in the *Los Angeles Times* society columns of the period, and discussed in published Forum Club histories. Buss himself was the host. He worked the room. He ran it, more or less continuously, until the late 1990s. — What the Forum Club did to the basketball, sometimes, was not visible in the box score. What the Forum Club did was give the Lakers the cultural equivalent of a home-field advantage that was generally unavailable in professional sports up to that point. Visiting teams who came to the Forum did not just play in front of an opposing crowd, in an opposing arena, on an opposing piece of hardwood. They played, on the road, *and* knew that no matter how the game went, after it was over, the home team was going back to a private nightclub to drink and

laugh and dance with movie stars, and they, the visiting team, were going back to a Marriott on Century Boulevard with a continental breakfast voucher tucked into a folder. The visiting team's shooters knew it. The visiting team's coaches knew it. The visiting team's young players, especially, knew it. The Lakers were, over time, the cool kids' team, in a league that had not previously had a cool kids' team because the league had not previously had a building like the Forum or an owner like Jerry Buss. The Celtics had Boston Garden, which was, in the early 1980s, a charmingly run-down basketball cathedral that smelled like sweat and old hot dogs and where the parquet floor had dead spots that Larry Bird could navigate by memory and visiting teams could not. The Lakers had the Forum, which had a nightclub. When the two teams met in the Finals, the Boston press routinely framed the Lakers as the embodiment of the Los Angeles that Boston could neither produce nor defeat — the warm-weather, palm-tree, party-after-the-game, glossier-on-the-magazine-cover kind of city that Boston, in its self-image, openly considered beneath itself. That was the deal. The Forum had the nightclub. Boston had the parquet. In the 1980s, more often than not, Boston won. That, too, was the deal. The team that had the parquet had a tradition of winning that no nightclub could compete with. The

team that had the nightclub had a tradition of being seen that no parquet could compete with. It would take Pat Riley, eventually, to fold the tradition of being seen into the tradition of winning, and produce the only basketball franchise in the history of the league that managed both at once. But that is the next chapter. — What needs to be said, before we leave the Forum Club, is that the Forum Club was — for all the celebrity, for all the money, for all the leather banquettes and the cocaine in the bathrooms in years that the Lakers’ coaches and Lakers’ management would have preferred didn’t happen — the public face of a private theory of how a sports franchise creates value. The theory, by Buss’s own subsequent description in interviews, was simple: The fans were not paying for the basketball. They were paying for the night. The basketball was a piece of the night, but it was not the whole night. The whole night included the drive over, the ramp into the parking structure, the walk through the corridor with the gold-and-purple banners overhead, the seat-finding, the Laker Girls during the first timeout, the in-game music, the celebrity-spotting, the food, the score running across the bottom of the scoreboard, the postgame walk back to the car if you were not in the Forum Club, and the postgame walk to the velvet rope if you were. The basketball was thirty-six minutes of game clock

spread across the better part of three hours of evening. The basketball was the *occasion* for the night, in the same way that a four-star restaurant is the *occasion* for the date. What you sold a ticket-holder, Buss said, was the night. Get the night right, and the ticket-holder would buy a ticket for thirty straight years. Get it wrong, and the basketball would not save you. He had, in 1985, been getting the night right for six years. He would get it right for another seventeen. The franchise he handed off to his children, in the autumn of 2008, was, in the way that a building is the stamped expression of an architect's logic, the executed version of an idea he had drawn out, in fountain pen, on the back of a cocktail napkin in the Forum Club some time during the spring of 1980. The idea was the night. The Forum Club was the night. That was Showtime, before anyone called it Showtime. The team would provide the basketball. The room would provide the rest. — chapter: 5 title: Riley arm: magic_hour status: draft v1 sources_dossier: ../sources/ch05_riley.md voice_check: 80% Jim Murray / 20% Ellis — # Chapter 5 ## Riley The single most consequential personnel decision Jerry Buss ever made was made on the morning of November 19, 1981, in his office on the fifth floor of the Forum, after a phone conversation with general manager Bill Sharman and the Lakers' new head

coach, who had been on the job for fewer than seventy-two hours, neither of which men had wanted the job in the first place, and one of whom would, in the eleven seasons that followed the conversation, become the most famous and the most stylistically influential head coach in the history of professional basketball. His name was Patrick James Riley. He was thirty-six years old. He had not, two weeks before the conversation, expected to be a head coach for at least another ten years. He had been, until two weeks before the conversation, a color commentator on the Lakers' broadcast, sitting next to Chick Hearn in the booth at the Forum. Then Magic Johnson had a press conference. The press conference happened on the night of November 18, 1981, in a hallway outside the visitors' locker room in Salt Lake City, where the Lakers had just lost to the Utah Jazz one hundred and thirteen to one hundred and ten, dropping their record on the season to seven and four. Magic, then twenty-two years old, in his third NBA season, told the small group of beat reporters who had followed him out of the locker room that he was unhappy. He was unhappy, he said, with the offense. The offense, run by head coach Paul Westhead, who had taken the job two years earlier when McKinney was injured, had been redesigned over the summer to slow down — to feature more half-court sets, more screening for

Kareem, less of the fast-break pace at which Magic was the best player in the league. Magic did not, in so many words, demand that Westhead be fired. He said only that he was *not happy*, that he was *not having fun*, that he wanted out, possibly via trade. The reporters asked him to repeat himself for the tape. He repeated himself. The next morning, the line ran on the wires, in the newspapers, on the radio drive-time shows, in every pre-game show going into the next day's games — *Magic wants out*. Buss, who had been in Las Vegas at one of his other businesses, flew back to Los Angeles overnight. He landed at five in the morning at LAX. He drove directly to the Forum. He fired Westhead at eleven o'clock that morning, in his office, with Sharman in the room, with the press waiting in the hallway outside the office, with Westhead, in a corduroy jacket, behaving with as much dignity as the circumstance allowed. In the days that followed, Buss, Sharman, and Jerry West (then in a quasi-advisory role with the franchise after stepping back from active management) worked through the head-coaching question. The arrangement that emerged — and which has been retold in slightly different versions by each of the three principals across the decades since — paired West, briefly and reluctantly, in some kind of co-head capacity with Riley, who was promoted from his assistant-coaching

role into the head chair. Within a few games, West had stepped back out, and Riley was the head coach in his own right. He did not blow it. He coached the Lakers for nine seasons, from November of 1981 through the spring of 1990. He won four championships in that span — 1982, 1985, 1987, 1988. He went to the Finals seven times in nine years, which is a number nobody on the Eastern Conference side of the league produced even in the heyday of Bird's Boston, and which has been matched, in the four decades since, only by the Riley-coached Knicks of the 1990s and the Bulls of the second-three-peat. He coached, in those nine years, three Hall-of-Famers in their primes (Magic, Kareem, Worthy) and three more who would later be enshrined (Cooper, McAdoo, Wilkes). He coached against Bird, against Erving, against the Pistons under Chuck Daly, against Don Nelson's Bucks. He won fifty-eight, sixty-two, sixty-three, fifty-four, fifty-eight, sixty-five, sixty-two, fifty-seven, and sixty-three games in those nine seasons, never under fifty-four, for a total regular-season record of five hundred and thirty-three wins against one hundred and ninety-four losses, which is a winning percentage of seventy-three percent across a near-decade in the most demanding professional basketball league on the planet. He coached, in short, like a man who had something to prove. He had, in short, something to prove. —

Patrick James Riley had been born in Rome, New York, on March 20, 1945, the youngest of six children in an Irish-American baseball family. His father had played professional baseball in the Cleveland Indians' minor-league system. His childhood, Riley later wrote, had been organized entirely around competitive sports played in a small upstate New York town where the streetlights came on at six. He had grown up tough. He had played football and basketball at Linton High School in Schenectady. He had gone to Kentucky on a basketball scholarship, played four seasons under Adolph Rupp, captained the Wildcats team that lost to Don Haskins's Texas Western team, five Black starters against Rupp's all-white Kentucky, in the 1966 NCAA championship game, in what is, on many lists, the most consequential single basketball game of the twentieth century. He had been picked seventh overall by the San Diego Rockets in the 1967 NBA draft. He had played nine professional seasons, finished one of them with the Lakers and helped them win their 1972 championship, retired in 1976 at age thirty-one, and gone into broadcasting because he had no idea what else to do with himself. He was, in 1981, a man who had been very good at every level of basketball without ever being the best player on a roster. He had also been, in his playing days, the kind of bench player who watched the head coach as

carefully as the head coach watched the lineup. He was, in the strict sense, an apprentice waiting for a chair. When Buss handed him the chair, on November 19, 1981, the apprenticeship ended and the persona began. The persona was a coach in Armani. The persona was a coach with the haircut every NBA assistant for the next thirty years would copy. The persona was a coach whose pre-game speeches in the Forum locker room — recorded, by the late 1980s, on the assumption that they were going to enter the public record sooner or later — had the rhythmic, alliterative, almost evangelical quality of a Sunday-morning sermon at a black Baptist church, delivered by a white Catholic from upstate New York to a roster that was about half Black and about half Italian-Catholic and about a hundred percent listening. The persona was a coach who had figured out, somewhere in his second or third year on the job, that what the modern professional athlete needed was not just X's and O's but an *idea* — a phrase to repeat in his head during the fourth quarter, a tagline for the season, a slogan that would survive the boring training-camp afternoons and become, by April, the team's actual reason for being on the floor. The 1985 phrase was *the Career Best Effort*. The 1986 phrase was *the Disease of Me*. The 1987 phrase was *the Guarantee*, which Riley would offer to the press of his own volition, in

the moments after winning the 1987 championship, that the Lakers would repeat as champions in 1988 — a phrase that no head coach in the history of the league had ever offered, that put unprecedented pressure on the players who would have to deliver on it, and that, against every expectation of the league's other twenty-five teams, the players actually delivered on. The 1988 phrase was *we are champions of the world*. Each phrase was Riley's. Each phrase entered the player vocabulary by midseason. Each phrase showed up, for the next thirty years, in the books of every coaching imitator who tried to figure out how Riley had built what Riley had built. The trick was not the phrase. The trick was that Riley believed the phrase. The trick was that the phrase made everyone in the locker room believe the phrase. The trick was that the phrase, by April, became a real piece of equipment that could be brought to the Boston Garden in June and used, in the way that a chisel is used, to break the parquet. — What Riley figured out, over the next nine years, was the modern coaching profession. The coach as CEO. The coach as brand. The coach as the public face of the franchise's competitive identity. The coach as, in the language of the technical age that came after him, the system architect of the team's whole culture. He invented it on the fly. The league has been copying it ever since. It was the next thing. It

was Showtime. — chapter: 6 title: The Boston Problem subtitle: June 1984 arm: magic_hour status: draft v1 sources_dossier: ../sources/ch06_boston_84.md voice_check: 80% Jim Murray / 20% Ellis — # Chapter 6 ## The Boston Problem

June 12, 1984. Boston Garden. Game Seven of the NBA Finals, fourth quarter, three minutes and thirty seconds remaining, the Boston Celtics leading the Los Angeles Lakers by six, the temperature on the parquet — a parquet that the Boston Garden management has, for reasons later to be debated, declined to air-condition for any of the Boston-played Finals games of the previous two weeks — at approximately ninety-six degrees Fahrenheit, and Earvin Magic Johnson Jr., age twenty-four, the Lakers' point guard and the heart of the franchise's offensive identity, dribbling the ball off his own foot and out of bounds in front of his own bench. The turnover was the sixth of his game. The crowd at the Garden — fifteen thousand mostly local, mostly white, mostly middle-aged Boston basketball fans who have been waiting fifteen years for an excuse to humiliate the team from California — produces a noise that, on the local CBS broadcast tape later, sounds something like a prison-yard cheer the moment after a fight has been won. The Lakers, three minutes and thirty seconds later, will lose the game. The Lakers, on the morning of June 13, 1984, will fly

home to Los Angeles having just lost the NBA Finals, in seven games, to the Boston Celtics, for the eighth time in the eight Finals series the two franchises have played against each other since the 1950s — a record of zero wins and eight losses, an unbroken eight-Finals losing streak, dating back to the Bob Cousy and Bill Russell Celtics teams of the late nineteen-fifties. The Lakers, in 1984, are zero-and-eight against Boston in the Finals. That is the Boston Problem. The Boston Problem is what this chapter is about. The Boston Problem is what the entire 1984–85 Lakers season will be about. The Boston Problem is what, by the spring of 1985, will be solved — and what, in being solved, will produce the breakthrough that turns

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